NO. 2 ARCADE · INTRO COMIC

Art direction

A friendly guide to how the game looks, so the comic you draw feels like it belongs to the same world. Everything here is an example from the game or the current comic.

Thank you for joining me. Have a look around, and ask anything.



THE BIG PICTURE

A GIRL'S NOTEBOOK INSIDE A WATERCOLOUR WORLD



The game's main menu: her school locker, painted in the same ink and watercolour as the comic. Every notebook, prop and sticker in it can be picked.

No. 2 Arcade collects 24 classic arcade games (1972 to 1985), each one redrawn as a notebook by the hero, Ruby, a 15-year-old who fills every margin with games.

The comic is the first thing players see. It tells how she fell for the little arcade on her street, and it ends at the locker above, where the game begins.

> So the comic needs to feel like the locker: calm, warm, a little nostalgic, clearly high school, never cartoony or childish.

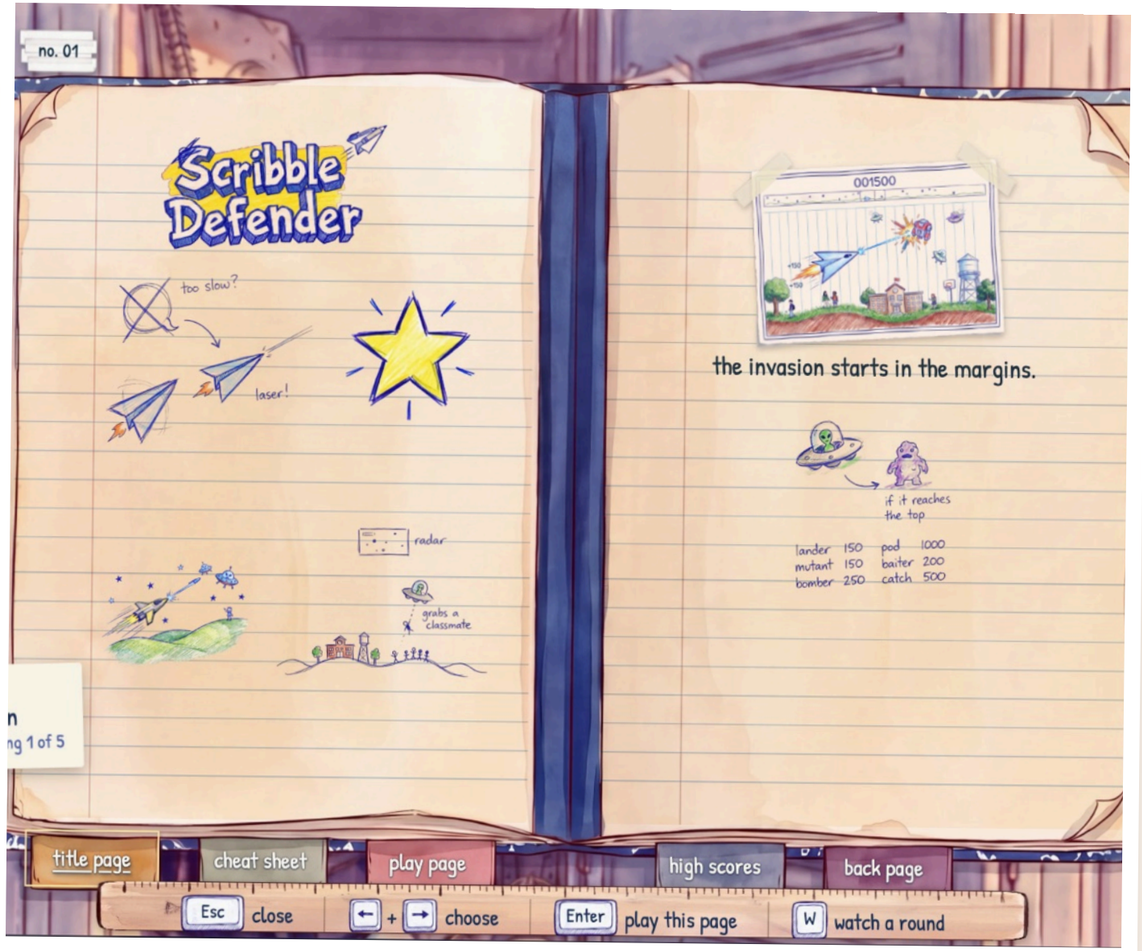
The world is painted. Her drawings are hers.

The world: ink and transparent watercolour



Everything real: school, street, the arcade, people. Fine sepia-navy line, washes that let the paper through.

Her drawings: ballpoint and coloured pencil



Her games, her notes, her doodles. In the comic, when she draws, it's graphite pencil or blue ballpoint on lined paper.

UP CLOSE

Line, paint and paper



Page 3 at full size: thin, confident line; soft blooms in the shadows.



Hands, coins and the lunch tray: simple shapes, warm light, paper showing through.

I love

- Fine ink in sepia-navy, never pure black
- Transparent watercolour, light to dark
- Warm off-white paper that breathes through
- Gentle blooms and soft edges
- Warm late-afternoon light

I avoid

- Heavy black outlines
- Glossy digital gradients or airbrush
- Photo textures
- Bright saturated "cartoon" colour



MY FAVOURITE PAGE

Page 3 is the one to match

Of the eleven pages, page 3 feels most like the book I want. If you're ever unsure about line weight, how saturated to go, or how much paper to leave, this is the page to compare with.

Colours sampled from page 3

paper	paper	light	warm wash	skin shade	shadow	sepia line	navy ink

her yellow	her denim

> Yellow is Ruby's colour. Nobody else wears or carries yellow, so she's always the first thing you see.

THE CAST

One sheet for everyone



04-characters/cast-sheet-v5.png. The thing I care about most: each person looks like the same person in every panel.

THE HERO

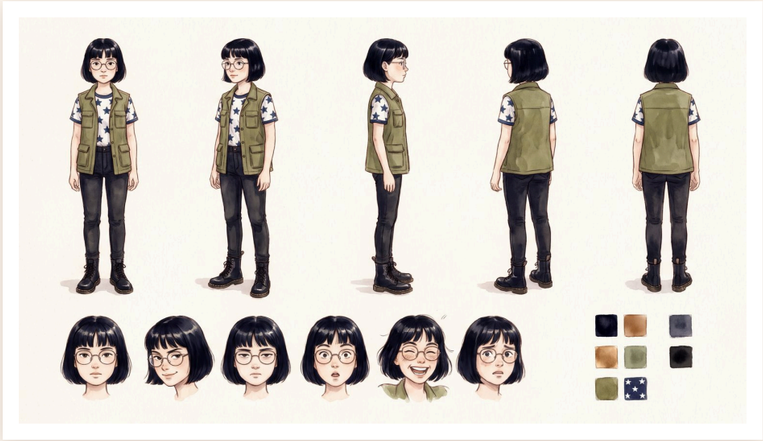
Ruby



Fifteen, stubborn, patient, and happiest with a pencil in her hand. She'd rather practise a run on paper a hundred times than waste a quarter.

- 14 to 15 years old
- Curly dark-blonde hair in a **high ponytail**, plain navy hair tie, a few loose curls at her face
- **Blue eyes**, every panel
- **Left-handed**: draws, writes and holds the pencil with her left hand
- Yellow pullover hoodie, blue jeans, navy backpack, a wide blue notebook
- White low-profile runners: crossed blue stripes, a thin red stripe, beige suede toe and heel, cream sole
- Her initials are RAD

June, Theo and Ace



June

- Smallest of the three, dry wit
- Black bob with bangs, round glasses
- Olive utility vest, star tee, black jeans
- Black 8-eyelet boots, yellow stitching (the one yellow exception)



Theo

- Cheerful, loud, always snacking
- Short locs; same build every page
- Blue and cream varsity jacket, round blank patch
- Red and white striped tee, charcoal joggers, white shell-toe sneakers with three black stripes



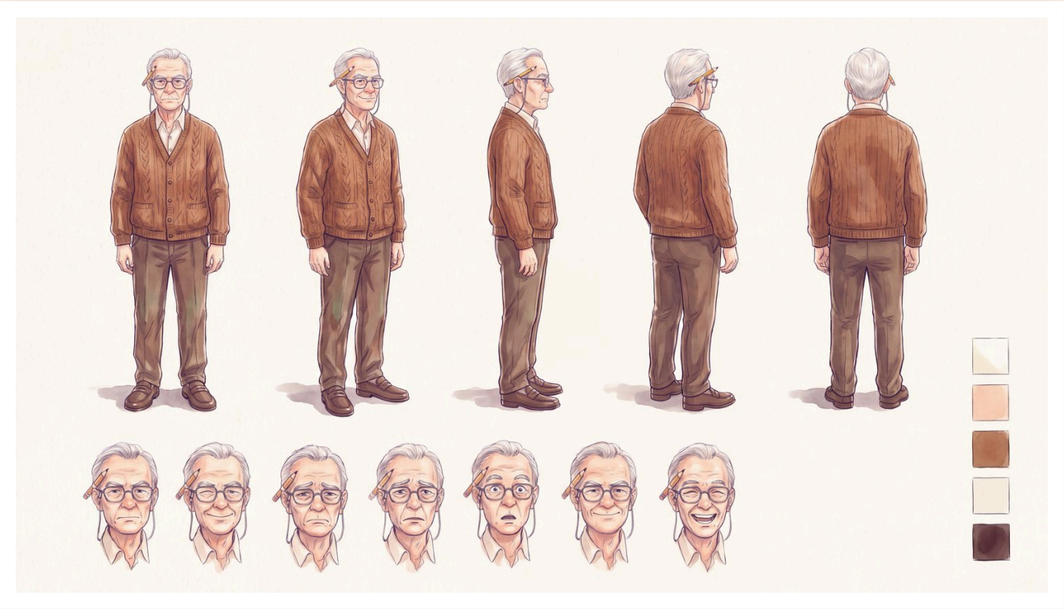
Ace

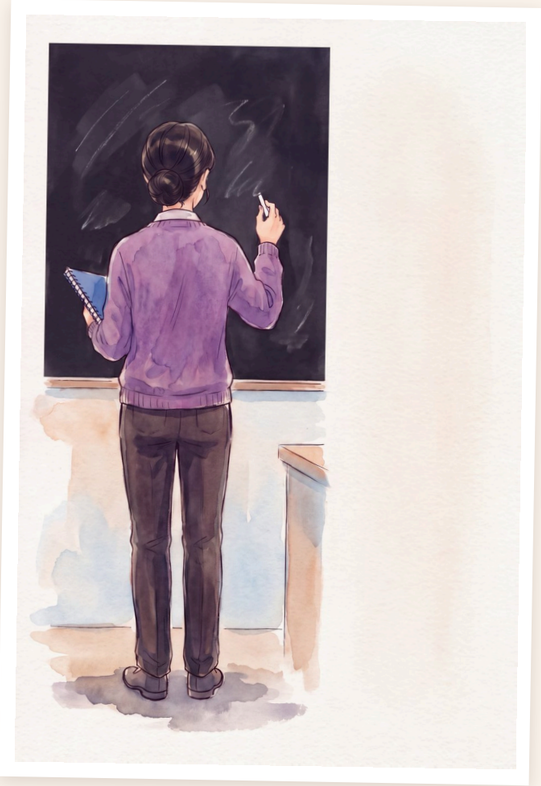
- Oldest and tallest, still clearly a teen; usually looks bored
- Long black curls, leather jacket, skull tee
- Black jeans, worn rip at his **right** knee
- Black canvas high-tops, white toe caps
- My own design: no resemblance to an actor or TV character

Names: in the comic only ACE is named (on the chalkboard). In the game, the who's who Polaroids in her locker show everyone's first name, and their full names on the back.

THE GROWN-UPS

Hal and Mrs. Albright





Hal, the owner

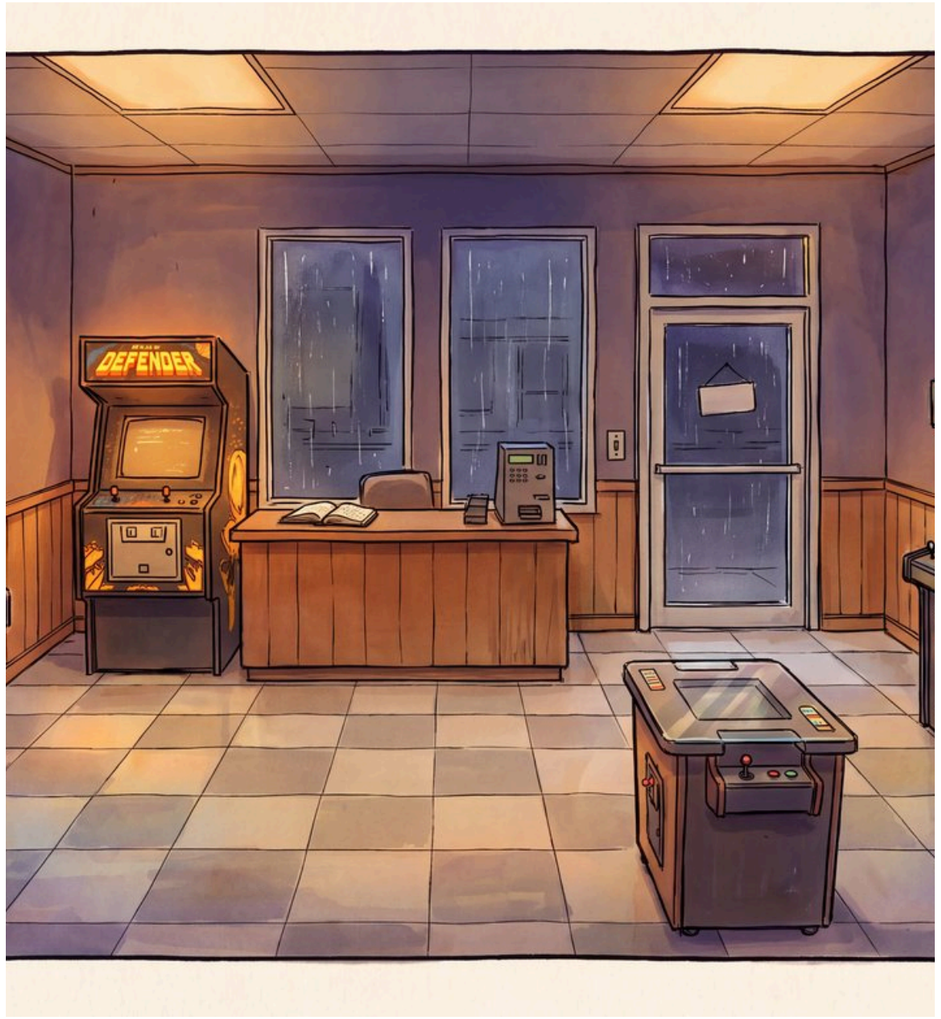
- Late sixties, gruff and kind
- Brown cable-knit cardigan, glasses on a chain, brown loafers
- A chewed, taped pencil behind his **right** ear, until page 8, when he gives it to Ruby

Mrs. Albright, the teacher

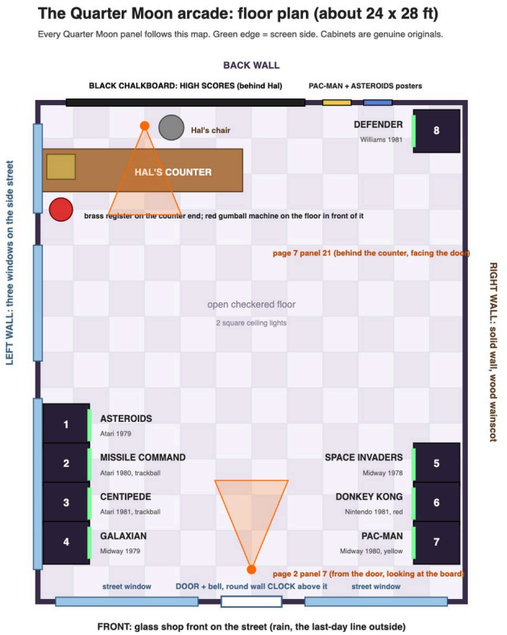
- Purple sweater, hair in a bun
- In the comic: only her sleeves, hands or back, never her face

THE PLACE

The Quarter Moon



The room: warm and amber inside, never a purple wash.



The floor plan: every wall, the counter and all eight machines have a fixed place.

- Every machine is a faithful painted version of the real game: cabinet, marquee, side art, screen
- Always switched on and glowing (except the page 9 blackout)
- Scores hand-chalked on an old **black** slate board behind the counter, with real game names and logos
- The gumball machine stands on its red stand on the floor
- Ruby's coin jar has a screw-on metal lid

The Defender corner



Page 8: Ruby at the Defender, June watching, Ace leaning on the wall.



The real 1981 Williams cabinet.

- A genuine 1981 DEFENDER, painted in the comic's style
- Its screen shows real Defender: scanner on top, hills, landers, little humanoids, the ship and its laser
- It never moves: back-right corner, back to the right wall, screen facing the room, posters just to its left
- Players hold the joystick in the **left** hand, buttons with the **right**



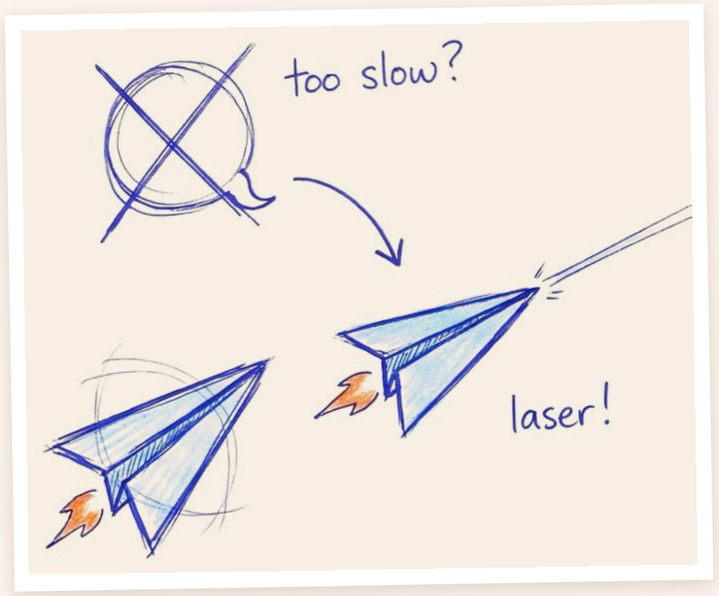
WORDS ON THE PAGE

Lettering stays on its own layer

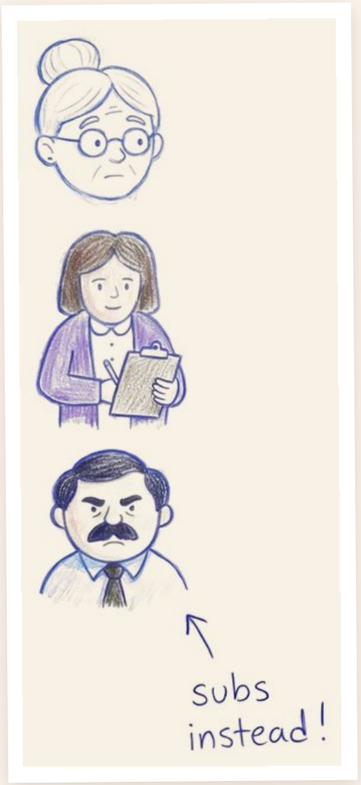
Balloons, captions and sound effects are added by me on a separate layer, in five languages. Please leave room for them where the current pages have them, and deliver the art clean.

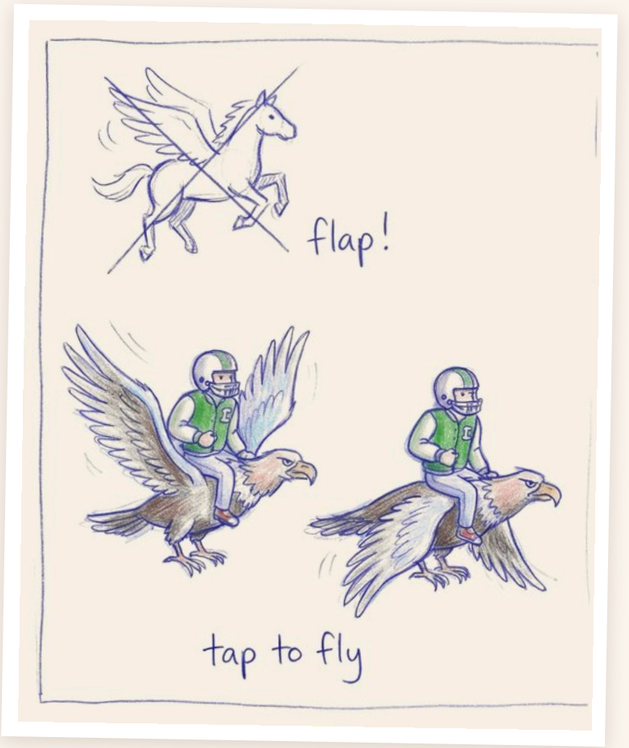
- **Painted into the art:** signs, the flyer, the chalkboard, marquees, anything printed in the world
- Printed signs look like real typeset print, in a high school world
- Never rainbow, bubble or cut-paper letters, nothing that looks like Comic Sans
- I don't use em dashes anywhere

How Ruby draws









Research sketches from her notebooks in the game: ballpoint and coloured pencil, crossed-out first tries, little notes. In the comic, when she draws, it's her own game's characters (the paper-dart ship, the saucer, the bug) in graphite pencil or blue ballpoint, never generic rockets.

WHERE THE COMIC LEADS

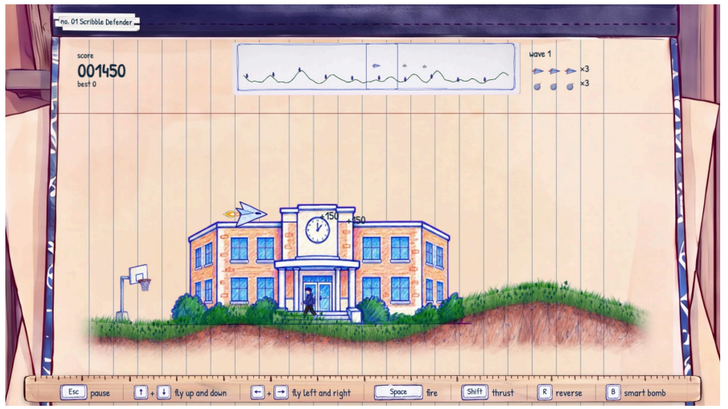
From the last page into the game



Page 11, the last page: Monday, at her locker, holding the No. 2 Arcade notebook.



...which becomes the live locker menu.



Inside a notebook: Scribble Defender, her version of the game from the comic.

> The comic hands the player straight to the locker, so its last page and the locker should feel like the same painting: same light, same paper, same hand.

A QUICK CHECK BEFORE EACH PAGE

Does it feel like my book?

- Does it sit next to page 3 comfortably?
- Is everyone on model: Ruby's ponytail, blue eyes, left hand; Ace's right-knee rip; Hal's pencil?
- Is Ruby the only one in yellow?
- Are the machines real, switched on, and in their places on the floor plan?
- Is there room for the balloons and captions?

Open to your ideas: the story is being rethought first, so pages, staging, camera, acting, lighting and pacing can all follow it. I'll re-letter, translate and re-record the voice-over to match.

Delivery: clean pages without lettering (today's are 3840 x 5760 px), layered files if you have them. Notes as a PDF or marked-up images are perfect.

Thank you! I can't wait to see her world in your hand.